



MG Motor India

Promoting Gender Diversity

Case Study

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*"The percentages are not the endgame... The most important factor is the commitment to Diversity, Equity and Inclusion (DEI), right from the leadership team to the last person within the organisation."*¹

– Mike Clarke, COO & CHRO, Hero MotoCorp²

*"It's crucial for everyone, including men, to understand the intricacies of collaborating with women and to cultivate a workplace environment that values respect and harmony."*³

– Yeshwinder Patial, Senior Director, HR, MG Motor India

*"We started with around 30% women in our workforce pan-India. Today, we are at 37% (which is possibly the highest in the industry) ... Our target is to take it to 50% by end of 2023."*⁴

– Gaurav Gupta, Chief Commercial Officer, MG Motor India

The leading British brand Morris Garages (MG Motor) was established in 1924 by Cecil Kimber. It produced sports cars and mini cars. After changing many hands, the company got acquired by the global Chinese State run SAIC Motor. In 2017, MG Motor India (MGMI) was launched at Halol, Gujarat, India. Further, it established Automated Guided Vehicles (AGV) along with Robotic Process Automation (RPA) in its workshop. Moreover, under the umbrella of its CSR, the company associated with NGOs engaged in providing quality education to girl child and included women in car assembly operations at its plant. Besides, through 'Drive Her Back' initiative, the company provided coaching and internal mentoring to women for a seamless adaptation to the corporate environment after a career break. It fostered technical excellence and motivated women employees along their career path. MGMI had commenced 'Women Interactive Network for Development' (WIND) and the goals included establishing leadership connections, personal branding, impactful communications, time management, health and hygiene, teamwork, confidence building, financial awareness

¹ Banerjee Sanhati, "For HeroMotoCorp, promoting gender diversity is more than a numbers game, says Hero MotoCorp's Mike Clarke", <https://economictimes.indiatimes.com/news/company/corporate-trends/for-heromotocorp-promoting-gender-diversity-is-more-than-a-numbers-game-says-hero-motocorps-mike-clarke/articleshow/105489623.cms>, November 27th 2023

² It is an Indian multinational motorcycle and scooter manufacturer.

³ Sen Anindita, "'Not a restricted area anymore to work on shopfloors....' MG Motor India makes strides towards gender diversity in automobile industry", <https://www.financialexpress.com/business/express-mobility-not-a-restricted-area-anymore-to-work-on-shopfloors-mg-motor-india-makes-strides-towards-gender-diversity-in-automobile-industry-3471529/>, April 30th 2024

⁴ "MG Motor aims for 50% women in workforce by 2023", <https://www.avtarinc.com/mg-motor-aims-for-50-women-in-workforce-by-2023/>

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and on the job training. Additionally, some vital manufacturing dimensions handled by women included paint quality, surface testing, research and development (R&D), and assembly. In effect, women had been active change makers and had driven a paradigm shift in the auto industry. Would MGMI be able successfully establish a 50% gender balanced workforce?

Women in Automotive World: The Changing Perspective

It was an accepted reality that women were invariably marginalised in most industries, however, it was grave in manufacturing, mostly in the automotive segment. Despite women's contribution at crucial historical junctures in automotive sector, they continued to occupy the periphery. This generally pertained to their working in office and scarcely in leadership positions. While this industry had grappled to minimise the gender gap to achieve diversity, yet such efforts got intensified gradually. Moreover, 2014 onward women's path had been cleared for leadership roles as well as to take on racing opportunities which had not been considered as an option.⁵

In sync with a global transformation and a mix of rising 'open mindedness and market forces' together were working towards creation of widespread prospects for women. Consequently, it had been duly acknowledged that the automotive industry was experiencing a dearth of appropriate tech expertise. With automotive companies undergoing digital transformation along with becoming software/digitalisation centric, obviously talent requirements were changing. Consequently, it was relevant for automotive segment to improvise its culture for attracting prospective applicants who might conventionally avoid a career in this field, like women. In effect, due to 'shortage of top tech and multi-disciplined talent', it was an excellent prospect for both men and women to build careers in the automotive sector. Organisations were particularly becoming cognizant of gender diversity while strategising 'hiring and promotion' processes opening up fresh opportunities for women thereby furthering gender balance.⁶

Conventionally, the automotive industry had been known for 'male-dominated work environments'. However, changes were afoot. Linda Jackson, CEO, Citroën, a French automobile brand, observed, 'There's a perception that it's a very macho world and I think we need to change that. It was a very macho world 30 years ago, but the world has changed.' Invariably, companies/organisations were undertaking drives to oppose stereotypes and dismantle obstructions to women's entry into this sector, yet there was much to be accomplished.⁷ Although women comprised half of the labour force, in automotive segment they occupied 'only a quarter of the auto manufacturing workforce'. According to Deloitte, "There is a large discrepancy between genders on whether attitudes toward women have improved in the last five years... Manufacturing firms and industry ambassadors need a different approach to recruiting, retaining, and advancing talented women in the workplace."⁸ (Exhibit I).

⁵ Nigrini Giulia, "Women in The Automotive World", <https://www.linkedin.com/pulse/women-automotive-world-chaiz/>, March 8th 2023

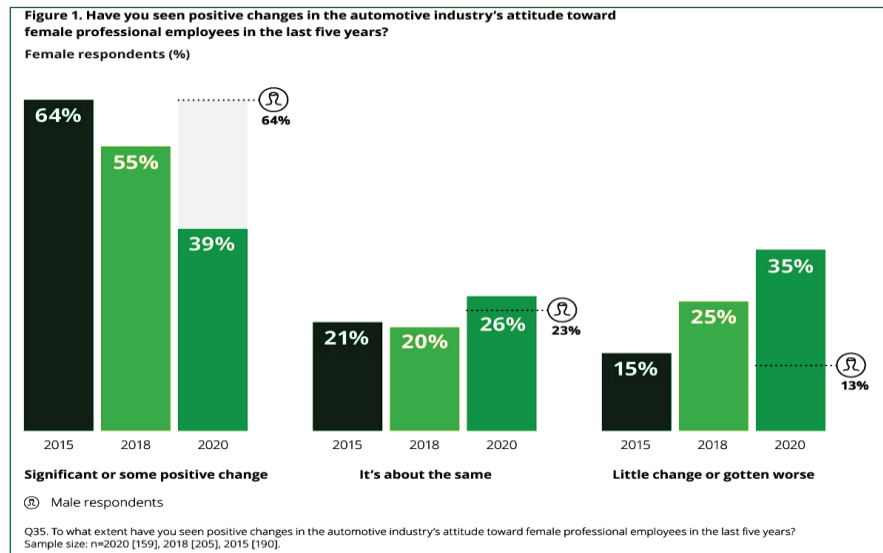
⁶ Revel Marie-Fleur, "There's never Been a Better Time to be a Woman in Automotive", <https://www.capgemini.com/in-en/insights/expert-perspectives/woman-in-automotive/>, December 18th 2023

⁷ "Women in the automotive industry", <https://www.arnoldclark.com/features/women-in-the-automotive-industry>

⁸ "Women and Diversity in the Automotive Industry" <https://www2.deloitte.com/us/en/pages/manufacturing/articles/diversity-women-in-the-automotive-industry.html>

Exhibit I

Changes in Attitudes towards Women in Automotive Industry



Source: "Women and Diversity in the Automotive Industry",
<https://www2.deloitte.com/us/en/pages/manufacturing/articles/diversity-women-in-the-automotive-industry.html>

The automotive career covered a wide span across 'engineering and car sales, marketing and finance, journalism, driving and design'. Still women were traditionally confined to 'generalist roles'. However, the positive contributions of women were being recognised. Although, attracting women to the automotive field was challenging, their retention was a further complication. A Deloitte study indicated, "A startling 57% of women working in the automotive industry feel that there's an industry bias towards men for leadership roles. If women working in the sector can't see a path for progression, then they're not likely to stick around for long."⁹

Status of Women in Automotive World

Women's jobs in the automotive sector were mostly limited to the back office. They often undertook lower-level activities like 'paperwork for finances, sales, and general office administration'. It was uncommon for women to handle middle management/salesperson jobs. They rarely occupied leadership/executive responsibilities and their presence in car manufacturing was dismal.¹⁰ Fortunately, numerous 'organisations, networks, and groups' actively enabled 'women and diverse groups' to overcome the hurdles that had conventionally held them back. Associating with such groups facilitated diversity, equity, and inclusion (DE&I) makeovers which called for strategic manoeuvres.¹¹

Moreover, women were progressively changing and reorienting the work culture in the automotive segment. They were successfully performing the tasks related to car designing and engineering. Inevitably, a greater presence of women in the industry led to more production of cars catering to a varied spectrum of customers. Furthermore, it was envisaged that the gender pay gap would narrow down and motivate more women to explore 'careers in

⁹ "Women in the automotive industry", op.cit.

¹⁰ "Women in The Automotive World", op.cit.

¹¹ Metz de Charlotte, "How the best DE&I approaches are implemented in the automotive industry", <https://diversityq.com/how-the-best-dei-approaches-are-implemented-in-the-automotive-industry/>, June 6th 2023

automotive design and engineering’.¹² However, establishing a diverse workforce was challenging yet crucial for the industry’s growth.¹³

Stimulating advances were taking place in the automotive sector represented by ‘EASCY– Electrified, Automated, Shared, Connected and Yearly Updated’. Modern cars were connected to the ‘cloud, digital ecosystem’ transforming the user experience as the industry adopted technologies such as ‘AI, 5G, augmented reality, data analytics, cloud computing, and cybersecurity’. Consequently, opportunities were being generated for entry level women engineers in the same proportion to male counterparts. Invariably, women professionals were also progressively rising ‘at the senior and middle levels of the workforce’. However, it was critical to uphold women’s career aspirations as they also needed time to address their household responsibilities.¹⁴

In the aftermath of global COVID-19 lockdowns which had critically impacted the whole of ‘automotive industry’s value chain’, they also triggered new approaches. The year 2024 had a stimulating potential for the automotive industry as it forayed into fresh ‘territories of innovation and changing customer demands’. There was a drift towards ‘increased adoption of Internet of Things (IoT), more safety features and online marketplaces’. The Indian automotive industry had gradually introduced ‘advanced driver assistance systems (ADAS)’ which enhanced ‘road safety’ and thwarted ‘accidents and fatalities’.¹⁵ Meanwhile, with the changing mindsets, numerous initiatives had been established to ‘achieve a more balanced workforce’ along with noticeable availability of ‘role models for young women and girls’.¹⁶

The evolving auto industry had been enriched with new technologies to facilitate ‘innovation, efficiency, and sustainability’. There was a tendency for recruiting women in significant roles of vital areas. Women empowerment was being practiced at companies such as ‘Kinetic Green, Mahindra Last Mile Mobility, Yokohama, Vedanta Aluminium, and GoMechanic’.¹⁷ Moreover, prominent automobile companies in India – ‘Maruti Suzuki, Tata Motors, Hero MotoCorp, Mercedes Benz and Mahindra & Mahindra’ were deploying greater number of women ‘from shop floor to engineering and operations management’ for better workforce gender diversity.¹⁸

Initiatives for Women in Automotive World

Continental AG¹⁹ had strategically initiated programmes for women resuming their careers after a short gap which included ‘reskilling, upskilling mentoring, and other leadership and

¹² “Women in The Automotive World”, op.cit.

¹³ “How the best DE&I approaches are implemented in the automotive industry”, op.cit.

¹⁴ “Navigating the Road Ahead: Future Trends and Women’s Empowerment in the Automotive and R&D Sectors”, <https://cxotoday.com/interviews/navigating-the-road-ahead-future-trends-and-womens-empowerment-in-the-automotive-and-rd-sectors/>, September 14th 2023

¹⁵ Raghunath Vinay, “2024 trends in the auto industry promise a focused approach”, <https://www.autocarpro.in/news/2024-trends-in-the-auto-industry-promise-a-focused-approach-118689>, January 13th 2024

¹⁶ “Women in the automotive industry”, op.cit.

¹⁷ Saraiya Kriti, “Women at the helm of auto industry – challenges and opportunities”, <https://auto.economictimes.indiatimes.com/news/industry/women-at-the-helm-of-auto-industry-challenges-and-opportunities/108270802>, March 8th 2024

¹⁸ Verma Prachi and Mukherjee Sharmistha, “Auto companies hiring more women to boost diversity”, <https://economictimes.indiatimes.com/industry/auto/auto-news/auto-companies-hiring-more-women-to-boost-diversity/articleshow/100335873.cms>, May 18th 2023

¹⁹ It is a German multinational automotive parts manufacturing company specialising in tires, brake systems vehicle electronics, automotive safety, powertrain, chassis components, tachographs, and other parts for the automotive and transportation industries.

career development initiatives'. During 2022-23, they had launched programmes like 'Launch-Pad, We-Lead, Unnati, and Women for Manufacturing' delegating women at diverse levels for furthering their contribution in R&D and manufacturing sectors. The objective of these initiatives was to attain 25% women participation at the 'first two management levels by 2025'. By providing equal opportunities to women, their goal was to ascertain 'gender inclusion in all roles across the board'.²⁰

Meanwhile, Mercedes Benz India – a luxury carmaker passed the edict that 'half of all its hires in the ongoing year (2023) would be women'. Santosh Iyer, Managing Director and CEO, Mercedes Benz India said, "The carmaker has a clear focus to increase gender diversity in the workforce." On the other hand, Ravindra Kumar GP (Kumar), the then Chief Human Resources Officer, Tata Motors stated, "Tata Motors is focusing on gender diversity especially at the shopfloor where 25% of all new recruits are women." The company had already engaged over 4,500 women 'on the shopfloors of its various plants, working across multiple product lines, rolling out everything from small passenger cars to sports utility vehicles and heavy commercial vehicles'. Kumar said, "In our Pune plant, we have an all-women TCF production line wherein women hailing from some of the remotest parts of Maharashtra are busy assembling our premium SUVs Tata Harrier and Tata Safari." He further added, "The all-women team plans, executes, and manages every activity on the line end to end, including assembly of all mechanical, electric, and electronic parts and components." Besides, Hero MotoCorp, India's largest two-wheeler maker had up scaled its recruitment strategy with 'gender inclusive policies'. It had initiated a 'Women in Leadership' programme for training and developing more women for occupying senior leadership positions.²¹

However, Volkswagen Group was leading the automotive industry with 42% women in their workforce, though the average standard in the industry was only 16%. Penny Burnett, Human Resources Director, Volkswagen Group, said, "The evidence is clear: when an organisation has a truly diverse workforce, it's more innovative, better at responding to customer needs and ultimately more successful." The Group commenced its 'Take a Step in Their Shoes' initiative which enabled 'men and women to pair up and shadow each other to gain a wider understanding of their strengths and work processes'. Further through '#DrivenWomen campaign', the company aimed to motivate women to build 'a career in the automotive industry'.²²

Admittedly, gender equality in the auto industry was inadequate, though the situation was improving. The visibility of women in this industry was increasing in the roles of 'racing drivers, journalists, manufacturing, and leadership'. Women had covered a lot of ground in this industry and were dismantling barriers creating fresh records.²³ **(Exhibit II)**. However, according to Charlotte de Metz, Chief People Officer, Keyloop,²⁴ "It is never easy to shift the status quo. Yet, through openness, cooperation, and dedicated action, we can all push the automotive industry forward and encourage more women into the industry."²⁵

²⁰ "Navigating the Road Ahead: Future Trends and Women's Empowerment in the Automotive and R&D Sectors", op.cit.

²¹ "Auto companies hiring more women to boost diversity", op.cit.

²² "Women in the automotive industry", op.cit.

²³ "Women in The Automotive World", op.cit.

²⁴ It is the largest global automotive technology company delivering cutting-edge solutions, tailored to the modern needs of auto retailers and OEMs.

²⁵ "How the best DE&I approaches are implemented in the automotive industry", op.cit.

Exhibit II
Few Inspiring Women Professionals as Leaders

S.#	Name	Particulars
1	Rashmi Urdhwardeshe	An automotive engineer and a Director of Pune Knowledge Cluster Foundation. She was also a former Director of Automotive Research Association in India.
2	Michelle Christensen	The Vice President, Global Design, Karma Automotive, she worked in car design for several years in the US and was a Senior Manager, Design at the Nissan Motor Corporation and was Acura's first female exterior designer.
3	Linda Jackson	A prominent British businesswoman had been in top leadership positions in the automotive industry for several years which included 15 years as CEO at Citroën and her existing role as CEO, Peugeot.

Source: Compiled by the Author from – Nigrini Giulia, “Women in The Automotive World”,
<https://www.linkedin.com/pulse/women-automotive-world-chaiz/>, March 8th 2023

Major corporations like JSW Group, Aditya Birla Group (ABG), Tata Motors, RPG Group, and MG Motors India (MGMI) had pioneered recruitment of women across levels ‘from shop floor managers to worker’s roles’ which were conventionally occupied by men (**Annexure I**). Meanwhile, ABG employed more than 50% women as ‘new engineering hires on the shop floor’. This was made possible due to ‘increased automation, relaxed regulations allowing women in night shifts in some states, and women-friendly facilities such as washrooms and daycare centers for mothers’.

Furthermore, MGMI was a leading automaker focused on gender inclusivity. It had adopted ‘gender-neutral job descriptions’ and deployed women in diverse positions. The company’s Hector model was exclusively built by an all women team. Such programmes together symbolised ‘a significant stride towards breaking gender stereotypes and fostering a more inclusive work environment within the Indian manufacturing industry’.²⁶ At MGMI, women were spread across engineering, manufacturing, field, HR, IT, and finance functions. However, Rajeev Chaba (Chaba), CEO Emeritus, MG Motor India, stated, “The company is looking at increasing this to 40% by the end of calendar 2023... Gender balance helps in bringing in diverse ideas, innovations and paves the way for sustainable growth of any organisation.”²⁷

MG Motor India’s ‘Drive Her Back’ Initiative: Will it Promote a Dynamic, Gender Diverse Workforce?

Morris Garages (MG Motor) a British brand established by Cecil Kimber in 1924, specialised in the production of sports cars and mini cars. Gradually the brand was acquired by diverse business groups and ultimately got owned by global ‘Chinese state-run SAIC Motor - the seventh largest automotive design and manufacturing company’. MGMI was launched in September 2017 at its manufacturing facility in Halol, Gujarat.²⁸ Furthermore, MGMI had formally declared a joint venture with the JSW Group in March 2024. The joint venture named ‘JSW MG Motor India’ was basically formed to concentrate on introducing ‘new energy vehicles to India’. The objective was to establish ‘a robust EV ecosystem’ for manufacturing

²⁶ “Indian Manufacturing Breaks Barriers: Women Lead the Way on the Shop Floor”,
<https://ipfonline.com/news/detail/industrynews/indian-manufacturing-breaks-barriers-women-lead-the-way-on-the-shop-floor/14577>, October 20th 2023

²⁷ “Auto companies hiring more women to boost diversity”, op.cit.

²⁸ “The journey of MG in India”, <https://www.carwale.com/news/the-journey-of-mg-in-india/>, June 24th 2019

numerous 'electric vehicles and plug-in hybrids'. Moreover, the JSW MG Motor India wanted to lead the energy vehicles sales in India by 2030.²⁹

MG Motor - a 100-year-old brand (1924-2024) had initiated numerous diversification openings for women empowerment. They had absorbed a maximum number of women in the workforce which consisted of about 3,000 employees. MGMI's workforce gender diversity stood at 37%, highest in the auto industry, while their goal was to achieve 50% gender parity.³⁰

To formulate workplace gender parity, the company discarded the conventional mind-set from the beginning itself. MGMI believed that work has no gender, although, the well-entrenched automotive industry had been deficient in gender parity, it was undertaking swift corrective measures.³¹ Prior to starting production, MGMI concentrated on the facets of 'diversity, community and innovation'. The company under its CSR introduced a range of initiatives – 'a skill development programme for underprivileged women, associating with NGOs engaged in providing quality education to the girl child and roping in women to assemble cars at its Halol plant'. Additionally, it connected with TRAX NGO to initiate community-based programmes stressing on 'health, road safety, and a clean environment'. Further, it oriented teachers while tutoring school students about road safety across 300 schools of Gurugram and Faridabad. In partnership with Baroda Citizens Council, the company commenced 'Prerna,' a one-year 'Skill Development programme' for 100 disadvantaged women. Thereafter, through 'MG SEWA', it provided financial support to them including their families. From 2018, MGMI had recruited numerous women associates in its manufacturing facility through diverse efforts. Besides, MGMI's state-of-the-art Halol manufacturing facility possessed 'Automated Guided Vehicles (AGV) and Robotic Process Automation (RPA) for various workshops'. Chaba said, "Technology is the greatest leveller, as at MG Motor India, a 22-year old female engineer teaches her 50 plus-year-old male boss on technology as he is not natural to certain things. With the rapid adoption of technologies like electric, shared and autonomous, we need young talent." He further added, "Our only challenge is to hire senior women leaders, who can groom these young women to become a better leader of tomorrow."³² **(Annexure II).**

The company acknowledged that for success and competitive advantage apart from a unique product, it also needed to espouse 'a forward-thinking work culture'. Chaba highlighted, "The Company works on the philosophy of SPEED, which stands for Startup, Passion, Ease of doing business, Execution, and Diversity." Meanwhile, at the assembly-line for 'MG Hector and the new ZS EV', women worked in 'quality control, body shop and paint shop' Chaba stated, "Gender diversity should not be just a symbol or tokenism to talk about on certain occasions. We need to dig deep into the issue and work at grassroot levels to make real impact."³³

Moreover, stressing on flexibility and support to working parents, Chaba said, "It is crucial to provide flexibility to both mothers and fathers, enabling them to work from home when

²⁹ "MG Motor India announces joint venture with JSW Group", <https://www.indiatoday.in/auto/auto-news/story/jsw-mg-motor-india-2517590-2024-03-21>, March 22nd 2024

³⁰ "MG-Unity in Diversity", <https://www.magzter.com/stories/sports/Auto-Track/MGUNITY-IN-DIVERSITY>, January 2024

³¹ Sharma Mamta, "Let people rejoin with dignity: MG Motor India HR Head Yeshwinder Patial on career relaunch programmes", <https://www.peoplesmatters.in/article/leadership/let-people-rejoin-with-dignity-mg-motor-india-hr-director-yeshwinder-patial-on-career-relaunch-programmes-33926>, May 10th 2022

³² "MG Motor India Leads In Empowering Women By Its Multitude Approach", <https://www.mobilityoutlook.com/features/mg-motor-india-leads-in-empowering-women-by-its-multitude-approach/>, March 8th 2022

³³ Chakraborty Neelanjana, "How a 96-year-old carmaker is breaking stereotypes to focus on gender diversity", <https://yourstory.com/automotive/mg-motor-india-gender-diversity-workforce>, March 22nd 2020

needed. By doing so, we empower our employees to balance their professional and personal lives effectively.” While underlining the importance of ‘educating and sensitising the workforce’, he said, “It’s essential for everyone, especially men, to understand the dynamics of working with women and to build a respectful and harmonious environment.”³⁴

As a proof of gender parity, MGMI had produced a car totally built by an ‘all-women crew’ which was the 50,000th unit of its Hector model. This had established a new benchmark to commemorate ‘diversity’ wherein women-only teams undertook – ‘panel-pressing of sheet metal and welding to painting jobs as well as carrying out post-production test runs’. Chaba said, “The rollout of our 50,000th Hector by an all-women crew comes as an honour to their contributions and hard work. It also demonstrates that glass ceilings no longer exist even in an erstwhile male-dominated industry such as automobile manufacturing.”³⁵ **(Exhibit III).**

Exhibit III

Celebrating All Women TEAM at MG Motor India



Source: “MG-Unity in Diversity”,
<https://www.magzter.com/stories/sports/Auto-Track/MGUNITY-IN-DIVERSITY>, January 2024

Arguably, MGMI had achieved considerable success in establishing gender equality at the Halol Plant in Gujarat. Starting with a 30% inclusion of women in the workforce, the company realised their constructive impact. The primary group included 20 women employees. However, it was vital to provide the facility of work from home to facilitate both mothers and fathers in balancing their ‘professional and personal responsibilities’. Yeshwinder Patial (Patial), Senior Director, Human Resources, MGMI stated, “...from 2017 to 2024, the journey has been remarkable which witnessed a good jump of 36 per cent women workforce. The company focuses on gender diversity as a whole. Not only white collar (work in office) jobs, we need to look at blue collar (manual labour) jobs as well.” Additionally, the women employees were provided training covering a series of aspects like ‘personality development, lifestyle balance and working culture’. This tailored strategy supported them in their professional roles while enhancing individual growth.³⁶

³⁴ Bhan Shereen, “MG Motor India looks to raise its women workforce to 50%”, <https://www.cnbctv18.com/business/companies/mg-motor-india-looks-to-raise-its-women-workforce-to-50-pc-17319041.htm>, July 24th 2023

³⁵ Naqvi Raza Shams, “A Car made entirely by Women: MG Motor Leads the Way”, <https://theguardian.com/a-car-made-entirely-by-women-mg-motor-leads-the-way/>, March 4th 2021

³⁶ ““Not a restricted area anymore to work on shopfloors....” MG Motor India makes strides towards gender diversity in automobile industry”, op.cit.

Women Centric Initiatives ('Drive Her Back')

To fulfill its gender diversity commitment, the company introduced the 'Drive Her Back' initiative in 2019 which aimed at reinforcing diversity and inclusion for creating an equitable automotive workplace across verticals. Further this programme aimed to bolster 'experienced and qualified women to re-enter the workforce'. The purpose was to avail 'skills and expertise of talented women professionals'. Patial stated, "'Drive Her Back' has empowered over 60 women across various domains, attracting over 2,000 applications. To expand the reach of our initiative, we've partnered with consultants and search specialists to broaden our search parameters."³⁷ Moreover, 'Drive Her Back' revival campaigns enriched the talent pipeline. During its third year most of the women participants were from 'non-auto industry' wherein it was essential to 'learn, unlearn, and relearn' in the fast-changing ecosystem.³⁸

A significant input of this initiative was provision of 'coaching and internal mentoring' to achieve 'their seamless adaptation to the corporate environment after a career break'. The company also partnered with Banasthali Vidyapith, Jaipur, in sync with its 'commitment to uplifting and empowering women'. Patial said, "...such partnerships go beyond the immediate impact...embody a long-term vision to cultivate diverse and dynamic talent within the automotive industry." Besides, it also fostered technical excellence and motivated prospective employees particularly women on their career path. At the company, women leaders were boosting efficiency in multiple domains like 'manufacturing, marketing, communications, roadside assistance, human resources and finance'. Moreover, women were undertaking activities of 'Spray Painting, Press Shop and Body (welding) to Assembly, Testing and Quality check'.³⁹

Specifically, the company employed over 700 women from nearby areas of 'Halol, Panchmahal, Dahod, Mahisagar, and Chota Udepur' of Gujarat. Patial stated, "Women at MG Motor India hold key positions across various functions, including Communication, Legal, Plant HR, Corporate HR, CRM, Manufacturing, Environmental Health, and Safety, Finance, Sales, Engineering, Purchase & Supply chain, demonstrating our commitment towards gender diversity." As a part of the company's hiring approach he added, "MG Motor India aims to ensure equal representation of women across all functions, and will be increasing the number of women in its workforce to 50% in the coming years... The brand is now gearing up to announce the 5th edition of 'Drive Her Back' campaign soon."⁴⁰

MGMI's intervention of 'Women Interactive Network for Development (WIND) initiative' aimed at women's development comprising of 'establishing leadership connections, sessions on personal branding, communicating with impact, sessions with women leaders, time management, health and hygiene, teamwork, confidence-building session, on-the-job training and financial awareness'. Patial said, "This helps women employees nurture their skills, unlock their full potential, and propel their careers to new heights." He further added, "Women have

³⁷ Ahluwalia Prachi, "Women's Day in automotive sector: MG Motor India accelerates gender diversity with 'Drive Her Back' initiative", <https://timesofindia.indiatimes.com/auto/policy-and-industry/womens-day-in-automotive-sector-mg-motor-india-accelerates-gender-diversity-with-drive-her-back-initiative/articleshow/108324399.cms>, March 8th 2024

³⁸ "Let people rejoin with dignity: MG Motor India HR Head Yeshwinder Patial on career relaunch programmes", op.cit.

³⁹ Mobin Yumna, "How women employees are faring in Automobile sector in India", <https://hr.economictimes.indiatimes.com/news/workplace-4-0/diversity-and-inclusion/how-women-employees-are-faring-in-automobile-sector-in-india/103164757>, August 29th 2023

⁴⁰ "Women's Day in automotive sector: MG Motor India accelerates gender diversity with 'Drive Her Back' initiative", op.cit.

been active change-makers and are at the helm of numerous roles/functions at the company, thereby driving a paradigm shift in the automotive industry... We are focusing on not just hiring more women, but also grooming and the growth of a greater number of women to leadership positions.” Furthermore, some vital manufacturing dimensions covered by women were – ‘paint quality, surface testing, research and development (R&D), and assembly’.⁴¹ Meanwhile, MGMI at its Halol plant provided women with hostel accommodations comprising ‘safe, sanitised, and comfortable living spaces’ to ascertain ‘peace of mind and physical well-being’. Besides, this improved the diversity ratio leading to creation of vibrant ecosystem for women in the workforce.⁴² The company had utilised the National Employability Enhancement Scheme to interact with panchayats around Halol to seek and motivate women aspirants. Moreover, MGMI had employed women in most areas across its plant – ‘manufacturing, maintenance and supply chain’.⁴³ Further, the company had ‘Worth Waiting For’ programme wherein customers supported young girls’ education as a part of its ‘unique socio-marketing strategy’. Chaba underlined, “As a part of ‘Worth Waiting For’ programme, we are enabling our customers to make a difference and transform communities.”⁴⁴

In association with The Better India⁴⁵ MGMI had endeavoured to emphasise and acknowledge the unique narratives of six women changemakers who ushered in affirmative community transformation. These six women included ‘transgender activist Kalki Subramaniam; Padma Shri awardee Sudha Varghese; women-led rural banking pioneer Chetna Sinha; India’s youngest *sarpanch* Jabna Chauhan; Dr Rani Bang; and the founder of North-East Network (NEN), Monisha Behal’. In these efforts, MGMI received ‘synergistic support through UN Women India MCO’, which had championed ‘gender equality across the Asian Subcontinent’. According to Chaba, “MG in India has been built on the strong foundations of cultural diversity and to reinforce this vision, we aim to highlight and recognise six women catalysts of change for their significant contribution to uplift the communities through the #MGChangemakers campaign.” Meanwhile, Dhimant Parekh, Founder and CEO, The Better India, stated, “As India’s largest platform for changemakers, The Better India has always sought to showcase inspirational stories which touch and impact people across the country. These women are making a difference in the lives of countless others with their ground-breaking work... We are excited to partner with MG Motor India to bring into the limelight the stories of these exceptional women, who’ve truly made the country better with their work and are driving India into the future.”⁴⁶

The Benefits and Challenges

Gender diverse businesses led to better performance due to a range of ‘ideas, attitudes, and approaches’. The diversity initiatives were supported by WiBC National Charter which opposed industrial norms which did not support women employees. The range of barriers in the automotive industry comprised of work shifts and a denial of ‘flexible working; women’s health and menopause, periods, pregnancy, inadequate toilet facilities’ along with biased ‘macho

⁴¹ “How women employees are faring in Automobile sector in India”, op.cit.

⁴² “MG-Unity in Diversity”, op.cit.

⁴³ Menon K Murali, “Closing the workplace gender gap”, <https://www.autocarpro.in/feature/closing-the-workplace-gender-gap-55804>, May 7th 2020

⁴⁴ “How a 96-year-old carmaker is breaking stereotypes to focus on gender diversity”, op.cit.

⁴⁵ It is the world’s largest impact-driven, positive stories platform.

⁴⁶ “MG Motor India launches branded content #MGChangemakers initiative with The Better India”, <https://www.buzzincontent.com/story/mg-motor-india-launches-branded-content--mgchangemakers-initiative-with-the-better-india/>, July 10th 2018

culture'. Louise Cheeseman, Director, Bus, Transport for London⁴⁷ (TfL) said: "It is only right that women, whatever their background, have equal access to...opportunities and a workplace designed around their needs."⁴⁸

Manufacturing industry posed exceptional complexities for women engineers necessitating adequate redressal based on 'societal, governmental, educational, and corporate efforts'. This strategy stressed on an environment wherein women could undertake 'education in STEM fields' to avail opportunities within the industry.⁴⁹ According to Patial, "We are committed to inclusivity and strive to build a diverse and talented workforce where all employees have access to equal opportunities. The fourth season of the 'Drive Her Back' initiative is a testament to our dedication to empowering women and promoting gender diversity within our company."⁵⁰

Meanwhile, Chaba opined, "In India, breaking stereotypes has been a big challenge... We need to have more education and collaboration for the whole workforce. While numbers are the first step, what's important is how you include both men and women to create a collaborative workforce." There was an opinion that auto industry used heavy machinery which could not be managed by women and this acted as a key deterrent for their entering the workforce, necessitating a dismantling of this stereotype.⁵¹ Despite auto companies motivating women participation in 'critical and integral operations of the factory', a few challenges persisted limiting women's participation in shop floor activities – 'gender bias, unhygienic work environments, lack of appropriate women's restrooms and safety issues' as well as 'lack of awareness'.⁵²

The auto industry was beset with few complexities arising from pre-set perceptions. However, in the era of automation there had been a paradigm shift in this industry. In modern times women needed to usually move into new tech-savvy roles.⁵³ Company executives of MGMI, Hero MotoCorp, Mercedes-Benz, and Tata Motors were increasingly focusing on 'women participation in leadership positions'.⁵⁴ Meanwhile, Suneela MVS, Head PMO – BALCO Group (Vedanta Group), Chhattisgarh said, "The industry is also becoming increasingly skill-oriented, with technology integration offering a level playing field for all professionals. Proactively developing digital-first skills can help women avail of the many new career avenues set to explode in this growing industry."⁵⁵

The Way Forward

The process of recruiting and sustaining diverse workforce was an immense challenge since there was a shortage of skilled women professionals across 'entry, mid and senior-level job' roles. The HR team could provide varied profiles for creation of a comprehensive talent pool

⁴⁷ It is a local government body responsible for most of the transport network in London, United Kingdom

⁴⁸ "Improving gender balance in automotive", <https://www.smmmt.co.uk/2023/12/working-women-what-the-industry-is-doing-to-attract-female-skills/>, December 7th 2023

⁴⁹ "Navigating the Road Ahead: Future Trends and Women's Empowerment in the Automotive and R&D Sectors", op.cit.

⁵⁰ "MG Motor India's 'Drive Her Back' initiative empowers women", <https://www.bureaucratsindia.in/blogdetail/mg-motor-indias-drive-her-back-initiative-empowers-women-to-pursue-their-dreams-after-a-career-break>, May 5th 2023

⁵¹ "How a 96-year-old carmaker is breaking stereotypes to focus on gender diversity", op.cit.

⁵² "Women at the helm of auto industry – challenges and opportunities", op.cit.

⁵³ "Closing the workplace gender gap", op.cit.

⁵⁴ "Auto companies hiring more women to boost diversity", op.cit.

⁵⁵ "Women at the helm of auto industry – challenges and opportunities", op.cit.

along with plans to nurture/encourage fresh talent.⁵⁶ Moreover, it was crucial to on-board expertise in domains such as 'EV engineering, sustainable battery design, renewable energy systems, as well as roles not traditionally associated with the auto industry - software engineers, data scientists, chemists, cybersecurity specialists, electronics technicians' to achieve the preferred transformation. Furthermore, persistent women centric efforts were critical for evolving tech roles in the auto industry. In effect, it was not a small shift but an authentic 'talent revolution'.⁵⁷ According to Mike Hawes, Chief Executive and Chair of the Automotive Council UK Competitiveness and Business Environment Group, SMMT,⁵⁸ "With so much change taking place across the automotive sector, recruiting the brightest and the best is essential to the future success of the industry... The industry has often been perceived – and the facts back it up – as male dominated. We need to change this quickly; gender balance is not just about 'doing the right thing', it's demonstrably good for business."⁵⁹ Adding to that, Jody Stidham, MD for Deloitte's global automotive practice, stated, "The automotive business is going through a massive transformation right now. This is the most opportune time for creating opportunities for women."⁶⁰ Would MGMI be able to structure a successful business growth path based on gender equity?

⁵⁶ "Closing the workplace gender gap", op.cit.

⁵⁷ Julitz John, "Buckle Up – The Automotive Industry is Shifting Gears", <https://workforce-resources.manpowergroup.com/blog/buckle-up-the-automotive-industry-is-shifting-gears>, February 21st 2024

⁵⁸ It is one of the largest and most influential trade associations in the UK and its resources, reputation, and unrivalled automotive data place at the heart of the UK automotive industry.

⁵⁹ "Improving gender balance in automotive", op.cit.

⁶⁰ Ruggles Megan, "Why aren't more women joining automotive manufacturing?", <https://www.hrdive.com/news/women-in-auto-manufacturing-gender-diversity-labor-recruiting-retention/713527/>, April 19th 2024

Annexure I
Women in Action at Automotive Shop floor



Source: “Indian Manufacturing Breaks Barriers: Women Lead the Way on the Shop Floor”,
<https://ipfonline.com/news/detail/industrynews/indian-manufacturing-breaks-barriers-women-lead-the-way-on-the-shop-floor/14577>, October 20th 2023

Annexure II
Women involved in Various Activities at MG Motor India



Source: “MG Motor India Leads In Empowering Women By Its Multitude Approach”,
<https://www.mobilityoutlook.com/features/mg-motor-india-leads-in-empowering-women-by-its-multitude-approach/>, March 8th 2022